

audience. ”

MICHAEL TIPPETT

A period of development

Tippett enrolled at the Royal College of Music the following year, graduating with a music degree in 1928. His attempts at composing were unsatisfactory, so he returned to take a course in counterpoint, after which he felt ready to begin his career in music. To support his composing, he took a job as conductor of the South London Orchestra, a publicly funded ensemble for unemployed musicians. It was a time of important personal as well as musical development: he began a serious relationship with Wilfred Franks, to whom he dedicated his first mature composition, the String Quartet No. 1; he also became more politically active, briefly joining the Communist Party.

However, Tippett's career was interrupted by a crisis of confidence. He was devastated by the end of his relationship with Franks in 1938 and struggling to come to terms with his homosexuality. Doubting his worth as a composer, he embarked on a course of Jungian psychoanalysis. This form of therapy gave him the confidence, and the inspiration, to persevere with his composition free from anxiety over his sexuality. The first work to emerge from this period was the oratorio *A Child of Our Time*.